We Burn Undead

In the Dragon Isles there is no priest who lifts a holy symbol and sends the skeletons scattering. You don't turn undead. You burn undead. The dead are dry: old bone, grave-linen, tomb-dust, the leathered husk of a thing that stopped drinking centuries ago. Nothing takes a torch more gladly. Light the barrow, and stand back.

"We burn undead." — the old barrow wisdom, and more oil than sense.

At the Battle of the Thousandfold Curses the Eldar had the Kha'din trapped in the Wintercrowns, and were losing. Reshuk, god of the dead, offered a bargain: he would send his children to win the war, if the living promised to feed them. The Eldar agreed. The fallen on the field rose not alive, but Deurg'Gul, the Undying Ones — what lesser tongues call the Fallen. By dawn they had turned their blades on kin. The Undying Lands became Sepulchre: Dearg-dul country, Tir'Na'Deurg'Gul, the Sea of Bones. Some say the Kha'din's own curses raised the dead, and Reshuk only turned them. Every later thrall, barrow-wight, Zuhl, and vampire lord comes of that bargain.

Hunger, age, and disease leave them alone. Spears, arrows, even a sword thrust into the gaps of plate — veterans say none of it told. Magicks aimed at the living fail: *illusion, charm, sleep, fear, hold*. The joys of life are shut besides. They cannot bear sunlight, cannot cross running water, cannot enter a house uninvited, cannot take bread nor ale nor salt. Beasts see them true, and will not bear them.

The old tales wander, but the oldest say fyre maketh et goote. Show them fire and the husks that fear it recoil — a torch in the barrow, a brand in the press, holy oil on the step. Drive them from the light. Torch, oil, naphtha, a thrown pot, holy water, holy oil. Willful undead laugh at a bare flame. Bring more oil than you think you need.

They remember what they were. Heart turns them because you call up what they miss. The fyre brand is what they cannot endure.

Anyone they slew may look only dead — a friend, a hireling, a Boss's sworn hand. Carry them home for a clean burial and by Midnight they may rise as that thing's spawn. Put them on the pyre with the bones and they rest. Same choice when an undead Wound opens. When they wound you they do more than cut. The hunger that raised the Deurg'Gul is in the cut. As Midnight nears it grips, chills, and writhes.

> "They hunt the living. They can smell you. Hide all you like — they know you're there."

> "Show them fire. A torch'll turn the husks — they run from the light. That's as close as you'll get to turning. The willful ones laugh at a torch. Those you burn. Bring more oil."

> "What they take off you, you don't sleep back. A potion, a working — or you burn it out, and the fyre costs you."

> "Boys, hold Herrick down and bring the fyre, we need to purge him."

> "A wound from the dead is worse. It worsens. Come Midnight the cut writhes. Hold him down and bring the fyre. He lives, he's clean. He dies of the burn, he rests. You leave it, come morning he's gone — or he's one of them."

> "Burn the bones. Burn whoever they killed. You leave a body, it gets up."

> "Anyone they slay gets up. That's the whole of it."

Facing the Fallen

- Undead have unnatural senses that can find the living.
- Undead fear naught but fire, and can be driven back by fire.
- Undead cannot cross running water (unless carried).
- Undead do not die unless purged in fire or holy water (or holy oil, holy fyre, etc).
- Anyone slain by undead rises as undead unless you purge or bless their remains (e.g. with holy water).

Touch of the Fallen

You are **touched** when any part of an undead blow is left after you Defend with Fuel, even if your armor soaks the rest. Armor does not keep out the grave-cold. Cut the whole blow with Fuel and you were not touched.

Hit points lost to undead are Tainted and do not come back with normal rest. For example, a hit from a *wight* might inflict 6 HP, and if the character has 3 armor they will take 3 Tainted HP and will not return when resting or even sleeping.

You can purge Tainted HP from undead with fire. This expends one incendiary, and you gain a Wound equal to the total hit points of damage you are purging. For example, 5 HP lost to undead, purged creates a 5-point burn Wound.

You can purify Tainted HP from undead with holy water. Each flask of holy water can purify 1d6 HP of damage.

Healing magic and potions do not restore Tainted HP. *Healing Touch*, *Stanch*, and their like heal only clean HP. Two workings reach the Taint:

- *Sun Beam* (Vitae 3) burns it out the way fire does, with no incendiary spent. Anyone standing in the daylight may purge all their Tainted HP, and takes a burn Wound equal to the HP purged.
- *Cure Disease* (Vitae 5) purifies all Tainted HP in the creature touched, with no Wound. Undead Taint is a magical affliction, so the caster rolls Sorcerie against the Referee's Risk.

Tainted Wounds are more dire. At midnight, any character with one or more Wounds inflicted by undead loses an additional 1d6 HP.

Undead Specials

OSE specials may land on any touch; that is the ceiling and the default. Dial down only when the fight wants it: a named attack, a Spark, or the stronger specimen.

- **Ghoul paralysis:** by default, any claw or bite that touches may paralyze. Dial down to bite only, Spark only, or "ghoul leader only" as needed.
- **Wight drain:** by default, any touch curses a Trait (below).
- **Mummy rot:** by default, any touch carries the rot. Treat it as undead Taint and disease; *Cure Disease* is the clean cure.

Level Drain > Trait Curse

Level Drain is a classic ability of some kinds of powerful undead. In Burners, this ability is replaced by the Trait Curse. Rather than losing an experience level, the character has a Trait cursed each time they are touched. Roll to see which of your uncursed Traits it takes. Mark the cursed one. Undead that drain two levels, such as spectres and vampires, curse two Traits with each touch.

Its 1s hate you. A cursed Trait still works, but whenever you lean on it and dice hit the table, any 1 turns against you. Out of combat, a single 1 is a fumble. In combat, any 1 you burn through it, in a blow, a Defend, or a cast, wakes the curse, and the Referee describes what goes wrong. A cursed Trait never adds the item's slots to a 6, either. Where no dice are rolled, the Trait works as it always did.

The curse does not lift with rest or healing; only a great quest ends it. A character whose every Trait is cursed is slain and will rise as undead of the kind that cursed them (usually under their control).

Signatures. A cursed Trait keeps its Signature, and the curse comes with it: a named sword on a cursed Trait carries the curse into every blow.

Not only the dead. A night hag, a witch, a demon, one of the Kha'din, or some other old malice may curse a Trait the same way. The curse works as above. A character whose every Trait is cursed by such a thing does not rise as undead; they belong to whatever cursed them, in whatever way suits it.